CVSS 9.2 · CRITICAL

21 Oct 2026 · PHP ships an emergency fix

AI helped find a 14-year-old flaw in the code behind 70% of websites.

What did it find?

Swipe →

Subhadeep Ghorai

Why you should care

About 7 in 10 websites run on PHP.

WordPress blogs, shops, news sites. A server flaw can expose everyone who visits.

DOCUMENTED

W3Techs, 22 Oct 2026: 69.3% of sites with a known server language

Subhadeep Ghorai

What happened

Aug

Researchers at Calif, using AI, spot the bug

Sept

OpenAI finds the fuller version

21 Oct

PHP patches early. Governments pull sites offline.

DOCUMENTED

Subhadeep Ghorai

BleepingComputer, Decrypt, Al Jazeera

The idea

A hotel room nobody cleaned.

A guest leaves in a rush. The cleaner skips the room. The next guest finds their things.

Subhadeep Ghorai

How it works · 1

Servers reuse workers.



One worker serves visitor after visitor. Fast, because nothing is rebuilt each time.

How it works · 2

Request crashes
e.g. out of memory

↓

Clean-up skipped

↓

Leftover state
stays in memory

↓

Next request uses it

In PHP, that leftover state could let an attacker run code.

DOCUMENTED

Subhadeep Ghorai

PHP security team via Help Net Security

The fix, in code

```
// BUG: a crash skips the clean-up
try {
  worker.note = note;
  doWork();            // 💥 out of memory
  worker.note = null;
} catch (e) { send(500); }

// FIX: start every request clean
worker.note = null;
```

Full working demo on Wednesday.

What it means for you

- ✔ **Run a PHP site? Update to 8.2.35, 8.3.36, 8.4.27 or 8.5.12.**
- ✔ **Writing a server? Reset state on every request.**
- ✔ **See a security update? Install it.**

DOCUMENTED

Subhadeep Ghorai

Fixed versions: PHP release notes via BleepingComputer

Decoder card

A crash left memory dirty. The next visitor walked right in.

💬 AI helped find this bug. Good news or bad news for security?

WED · WATCH THE LEAK HAPPEN LIVE →